

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1988-01-14

1 dear bahá'í friends,

your letter of 25 November 1987 to the united Nations office of the

bahá'í international community concerning the issues of "indigenous

2 rights" and "self-determination" was passed to the universal house of jus-

3 tice, which has instructed us to convey the following reply.

with the coming of bahá'u'lláh and the emphasis that his revelation

4 gives to the oneness of mankind, it is inevitable that peoples in all parts of the world who once seemed dormant or who have suffered discrimination would rise to assert their place in society. As with so many fundamental

5 social issues, those concerning "indigenous rights" and "self-determination"

6 find, for bahá'ís, their proper expression and resolution within the con-

7 text of the principle of the oneness of mankind. however, as is often the

8 case, such issues are expressed in political forms which are unacceptable to bahá'ís, who conscientiously avoid partisanship, subversion, and the cor-

9 rupt attitudes and involvements associated with politics. At the same time, it is recognized that important issues of society fall within the province of

10 government and perforce engage political processes currently in practice.

11 increasingly, as the faith emerges from obscurity the bahá'í community

12 will find itself compelled to assist in finding solutions to the social problems afflicting humanity; it will have to be wise in its actions to avoid the pitfalls

13 of politics.

14 generally, the wisest course for the bahá'í community in controversial

15 situations is to remain uninvolved; however, at times when primary bahá'í

16 principles are at the heart of an issue, the decision of the National Assembly 46.1

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47 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

48 80concerned should not necessarily be to observe silence but, rather, to take

49 action which rises above the partisan political manifestations of the contro-
50 versy. The Assembly may, for instance, present its own statement to the au-
51 thorities, setting forth its views on essential issues on the basis of principle, letting the
circumstances determine how the principle is best to be applied. if you feel that such action
would be appropriate in the situation you face
52 with respect to the issues raised in your letter, you may wish to draft such a
statement, but before releasing it, kindly check with the world center.
53 concerning indigenous rights, it stands to reason that indigenous people
54 are entitled to all the human rights accorded other peoples. for example,
55 they should be guaranteed the full rights of citizenship, and all acts of dis-crimination
against them, which may have developed over the years, should be eliminated. At the same
time, it would be unseemly for the demands for
56 their rights to make, on the basis of their indigenousness, a special claim to
57 exclusive rights and privileges which exceed the necessity to redress injustic-es. The
bahá'í attitude on such questions should be guided by bahá'u'lláh's
58 teaching that "The earth is but one country, and mankind its citizens."
59 46-1
60 Thus it should be borne in mind that while upholding indigenous rights
61 may well deserve the support of the bahá'ís, often the viewpoints of those
62 claiming such rights are so circumscribed and narrow that bahá'ís find it
63 difficult to wholeheartedly subscribe to them.

The united Nations office of the bahá'í international community will

64 send you the statements requested in your letter.
65 with loving bahá'í greetings,

Department of the secretariat

66 46-1. gwb, no. 117 .46.4
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47 1986-1992 • The Six Year Plan
48 8147

Request Special Prayers for Bahá'ís in Iran

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]